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Metal Matters

Bullish copper to \$14.5k/t next month on arb tailwinds and growth resilience, \$15k/t within a year.

CITI'S TAKE

We publish March data for our global copper end use consumption tracker and revise higher our copper price forecasts to \$14,500/t near-term and \$15k/t over 6-12 months. US copper tariff fears are likely to remain a price tailwind through June until tariff clarity emerges. We think global growth and risk-sentiment can hold up in the near-term even if the Strait of Hormuz remains closed through to July, while an earlier or eventual deal (base case) to reopen the Strait should be bullish for risk assets. We are now also more conservative on copper supply growth and assume scrap and mine output underperform through 2026 and 2027.

We turn bullish on copper to \$14,500/t over the next month (having been broadly neutral since January, and previously bullish from Sep-25) and expect copper to touch \$15k/t within a year — We think growth and risk assets will be resilient to Hormuz Strait closure impacts for at least the next few months while also exposed to eventual or swifter upside from a potential deal. US copper tariff fears can remain supportive through June, and risks skew more bullish medium-term with scrap and mine supply growth likely to underperform this year and next against resilient energy transition and AI demand, with a ~360kt forecast deficit in 2027.

Lingering fears of US tariffs on refined copper may support sentiment until at least the end-June review deadline — We anticipate further strategic ambiguity from US policymakers rather than a definitive announcement of a tariff and believe that the administration will not impose a refined copper tariff but will avoid stating this definitively to maximise incentives to maintain excess copper inventory in the US. Post-June, lack of tariff clarity could become a headwind if the market fades pricing of tariff risk, but a supportive physical outlook and our expectation for a Hormuz reopening by the summer could offset any bearish impact.

We caution that despite resilient growth and likely tighter physical balances copper, along with many risk assets, remains subject to bearish tail risks from a sustained and unstable Middle East situation. Copper inventory levels and end-use consumption remain sensitive to interest rates and expectations, even though physical demand appears far more cushioned today from a cyclical growth shock than in the past due to assumed structural resilience of AI and energy transition demand particularly if higher energy pricing drives the shock (read more [here](#)).

Our proprietary tracker implies subdued copper end use growth y/y as of March amid subdued cyclical demand growth but also due to a y/y decline in China reported renewable installations versus a temporary high base in 2025 — However, recent improvement in global PMI prints suggests upside for cyclical consumption, which implied softness in domestic China energy transition demand (and other segments like property) is being offset by strong export growth. The implied slowdown in China energy transition demand is largely a function of policy induced front-loading in solar and EVs last year and is/was anticipated.

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See Appendix A-1 for Analyst Certification, Important Disclosures and Research Analyst Affiliations.

Copper risks turn bullish on arb and supply tailwinds, growth resilience

Upward revisions to our copper price forecasts and scenarios are summarised in Fig.1 and 2. We turn bullish copper (previously neutral) to \$14,500/t through June amid more confidence in broader near-term global growth resilience, US-arb tailwinds, and physical supply constraints outweighing bearish tail risks from a broader risk-unwind on sustained Hormuz disruption and/or higher interest rate expectations. We also hike prices in our bull case price scenario (albeit reduce the probability to 20%) to reflect upside if cyclical growth outperforms, rate cuts are repriced, or we see bull fundamental outcomes (stronger copper structural demand growth, further supply underperformance from mine supply and/or scrap).

Figure 1. Citi copper price summary of base case forecast revisions

Base Metals	Unit	0-3 mth pt price	6-12 mth pt price	2025f	1Q26	2Q26f	3Q26f	4Q26f	2026f	1Q27f	2Q27f	3Q27f	4Q27f	2027f	2028f
Copper NEW	\$/t	14500	15000	9950	12818	13500	14000	14500	13700	14500	14500	14000	14000	14250	14000
Copper (OLD)		13000	12000	9950	12818	13000	12500	12000	12600	12000	12000	12000	12000	12000	12000

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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, LME

Figure 2. Citi copper price forecast revised scenarios (ex-US pricing)

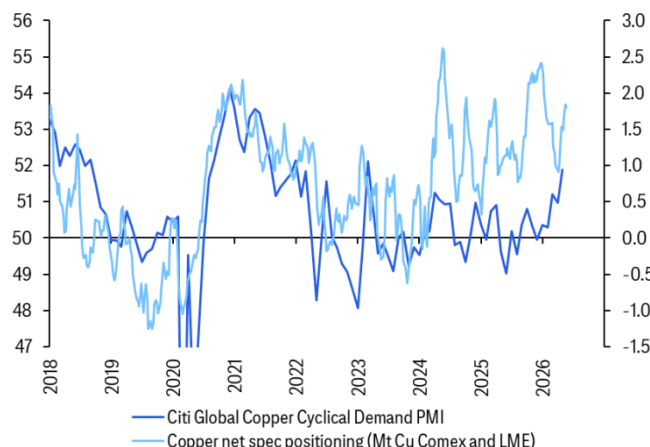
Price Forecasts	Scenario Weight	Unit	0-3 mth pt price	6-12 mth pt price	1Q26	2Q26f	3Q26f	4Q26f	2026f	1Q27f	2Q27f	3Q27f	4Q27f	2027f	2028f
Copper (Bull)	20%	\$/t			12818	14000	15000	16000	14455	17000	17000	17000	17000	17000	17000
Copper (Base)	60%	\$/t	14500	15000	12818	13500	14000	14500	13700	14500	14500	14000	14000	14250	14000
Copper (Bear)	20%	\$/t				12500	12000	12000	12330	11000	11000	11000	11000	11000	11000

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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, LME

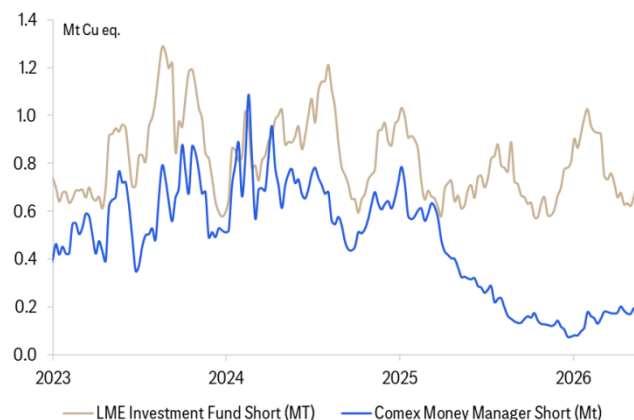
Net long copper positioning is now relatively elevated but remains below the highs of late 2025 and 2024. Funds gross short positions remain subdued on COMEX, likely partly due to lingering tariff risk and this is unlikely to change ahead of market anticipation of further tariff clarity by end-June.

Figure 3. Investor net long copper positioning has climbed in recent weeks alongside stronger PMI readings and broader risk asset strength (e.g. US equities)



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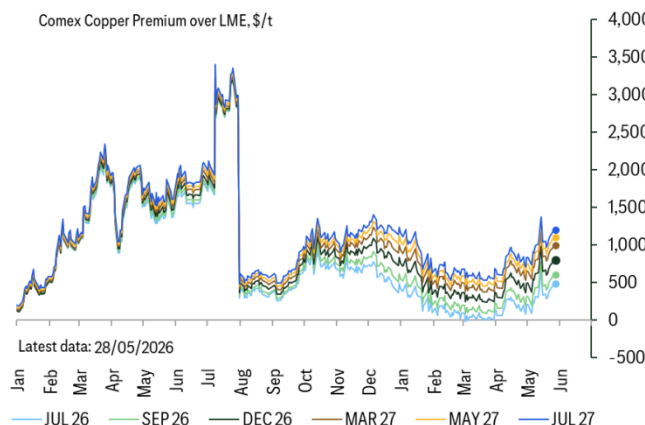
Figure 4. Funds are reluctant to be short copper, particularly on COMEX likely given lingering tariff risk, this could shift post June.



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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, LME, CME Group

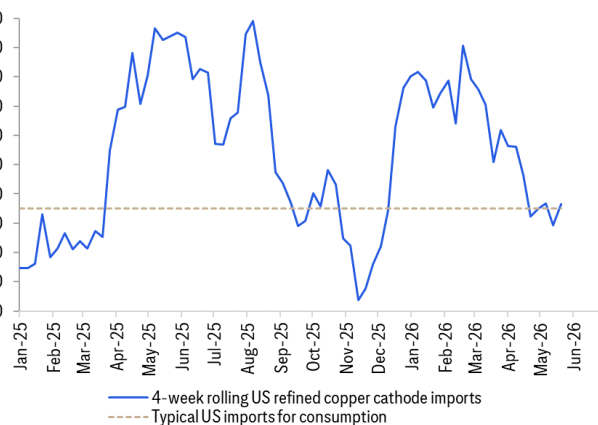
We think lingering fears of a potential US tariff on refined copper can support sentiment until July, beyond which inventory draws/reduced incentive to finance metal domestically can act as a headwind. Our base case remains that no tariff will be announced, but that US policymakers may opt to maintain strategic ambiguity rather announcing anything definitive to support continued storage of inventory within the US. This may weigh somewhat through 3Q'26, but our base case of a Hormuz reopening in 3Q'26 may offset downside, and any eventual inventory draws are likely to be gradual rather than sudden. In the tail risk scenario that tariffs are announced and phased from 2027, this would be incrementally price supportive, particularly for COMEX-prices that would reflect most of the tariff rate, and LME spreads given the prospect of further shipments of metal to the US ahead of tariff implementation.

Figure 5. The COMEX-LME arb has widened ahead of an anticipated review of US S232 tariffs on refined imports by end-June, combined with recent builds in fund length.



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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, LME, CME Group

Figure 6. US imports have matched typical import requirements for the last month or so, but widening of arb could incentivise a reacceleration of US-bound shipments



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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, US BOL

Figure 4 shows our tighter copper physical balance expectation for 2027 with an anticipated deficit of ~350kt basis current spot prices. On paper this would equate to roughly a \$1,500/t higher price to drive additional scrap recovery and substitution sufficient to clear the market, although we acknowledge some potential for a drawdown in excess US inventory that could absorb some or all this modelled deficit.

Figure 7. Revised copper supply and demand balance

kt Cu	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026f	2027f	2028f
Mine Production	20,752	21,179	21,808	22,395	23,128	23,398	23,352	23,789	24,542
% Change	0.7%	2.1%	3.0%	2.7%	3.3%	1.2%	-0.2%	1.9%	3.2%
Of Which Disr. Allowance (t)							977	1,818	1,942
Of Which Disr. Allowance (%)							4.0%	7.1%	7.3%
Refined Production	23,591	24,374	25,067	25,561	26,450	27,300	27,423	27,816	28,649
% Change	-0.3%	3.3%	2.8%	2.0%	3.5%	3.2%	0.5%	1.4%	3.0%
Refined Consumption	23,006	24,664	24,735	25,596	26,202	26,834	27,424	28,179	28,801
% Change	-3.6%	7.2%	0.3%	3.5%	2.4%	2.4%	2.2%	2.8%	2.2%
End-Use Consumption	24,110	25,848	25,922	26,824	27,460	28,122	28,741	29,531	30,184
Surplus/Deficit	585	-290	332	-35	247	466	-1	-363	-152
Av. Price (US\$/t ex-US)	6,183	9,318	8,830	8,485	9,145	9,950	13,600	14,000	14,000

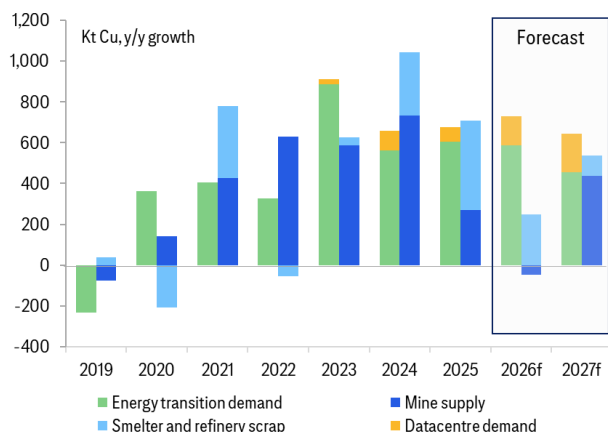
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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, Wood Mackenzie, ICSG, IWCC, LME, BGRIMM

Our mine supply growth assumptions are now weaker having applied a higher global disruption allowance of 7% for 2027 and 2028, while still expecting zero growth in 2026. We think a higher disruption allowance risk is warranted given increased execution and ramp-up risk across key mines (e.g. Grasberg, El Teniente, Kamao, Cobre Panama) and a less certain path for sustained elevated production growth in the DR Congo given current sulfur market constraints and broader elevated supply risks associated with the current environment of less geopolitical stability and greater reliance on share copper supply from less stable jurisdictions.

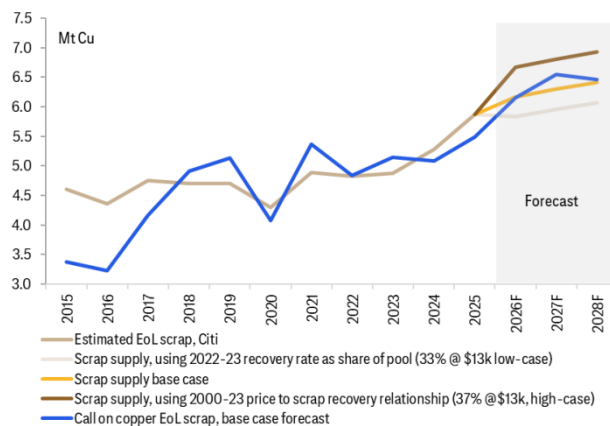
The global copper market is reliant on rising scrap supply (acknowledging 2025 surplus base) to meet structural demand growth in 2026 (Fig.8) given flat anticipated mine output. We now assume that scrap recovery will not rise proportionally to higher 2026 prices and will meet less than half this demand. China scrap import data (Fig 10 and 11) shows only a modest y/y uptick despite much higher copper prices of >30% y/y for Jan-Apr. Underperformance relative to price could be justified by the recent hikes to energy and fuel costs, softer goods trade-in-support in China relative to last year, and our belief in a generally depleted global scrap supply chain given broader shortages of raw materials for smelters in recent years.

Figure 8. Scrap and mine supply growth expected to fail to match AI and energy transition demand growth this year and next (if we assume any cyclical demand recovery the gap becomes more severe)



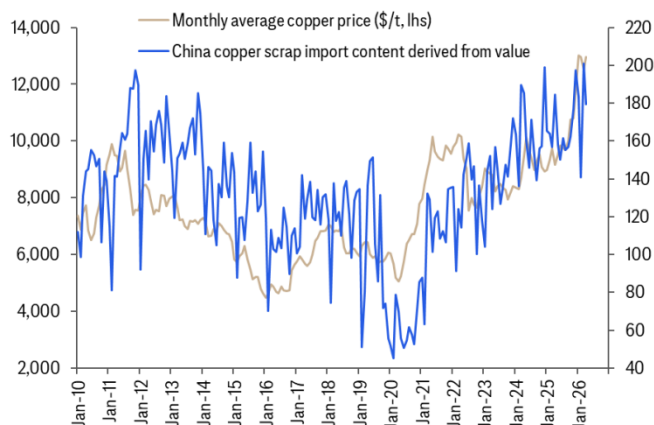
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Source: Citi Research, Bloomberg, Wood Mackenzie, IWCC, BGRIMM, ICSG

Figure 9. This reliance on scrap to meet projected demand is shown below as a rising "call-on-scrap" (end-use consumption minus mine supply)



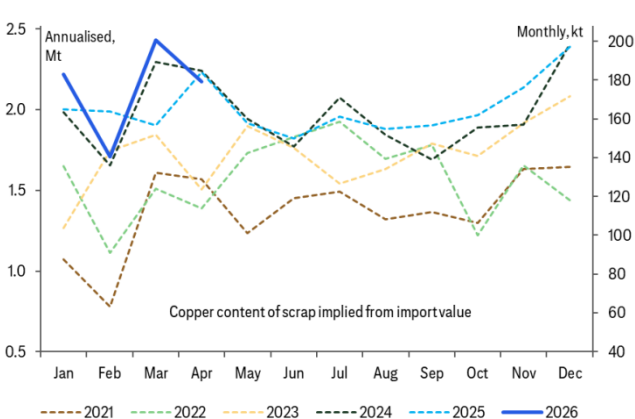
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Figure 10. China scrap imports implied from value have broadly correlated with price over time and provide a very broad measure of global copper scrap supply response



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Source: Citi Research, TDM, LME, Bloomberg

Figure 11. China scrap imports up slightly y/y, but do not suggest any surge in scrap recovery that might be expected given copper prices ~\$3.5k/t higher y/y in Q1.



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Source: Citi Research, TDM

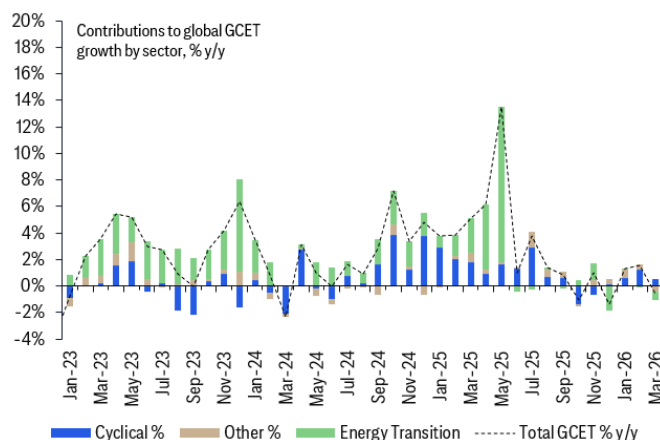
Power installations base effect weighs on tracked global copper end-use

Implied global copper end-use from our proprietary GCET tracker, declined by 0.6% YoY in March 2026, due mainly to a large statistical base effect from China renewables demand due to the spike in reported power installations in March 2025, cyclical demand components up ~1% y/y. We expect implied global copper end-use to remain subdued through 1H'26 as this base effect persists through to May, before these base effects likely turn positive from 2H'26. Cyclical end-use demand growth may have been stronger in April and May given more robust manufacturing PMI indicators, although upside may be relatively limited given the

prospect of some lagged impact from higher energy prices and lack of consensus pricing of meaningful rate cuts or incremental fiscal stimulus at present.

The structural drivers of copper demand continue to underpin demand growth. Increased AI-related capex spending, rising EV penetration, surging BESS installations, and a still- growing renewable energy pipeline remain supportive for demand. Despite year-on-year volatility in monthly implied power installation demand, we still expect copper demand growth from the power generation segment of ~2% in 2026. There is upside to these forecasts if the Strait of Hormuz crisis drives a lasting behavioral shift from drive governments and consumers away from fossil fuel reliance and towards green-energy solutions/alternatives, both due to improved relative economics and for the purpose of energy source diversification.

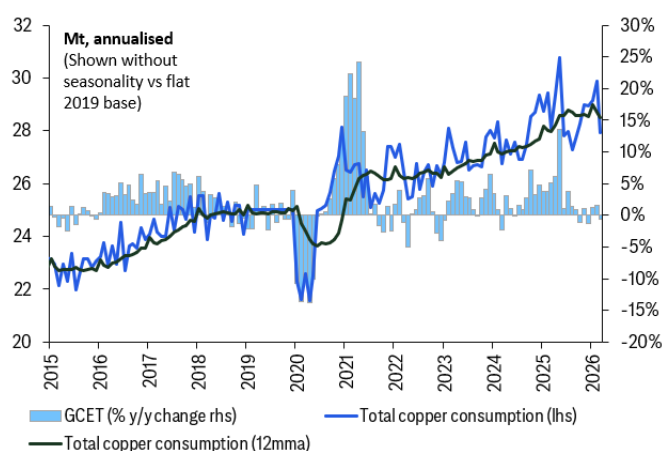
Figure 12. Energy-transition consumption weighing on implied y/y global copper end use growth amid base effects



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Source: Citi Research, ICA, Wood Mackenzie, Bloomberg

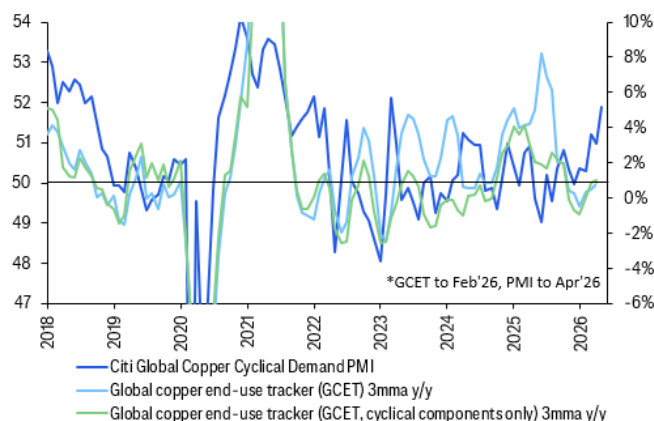
Figure 13. Total copper consumption annualizing at ~28Mt



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Source: Citi Research, ICA, Wood Mackenzie, Bloomberg

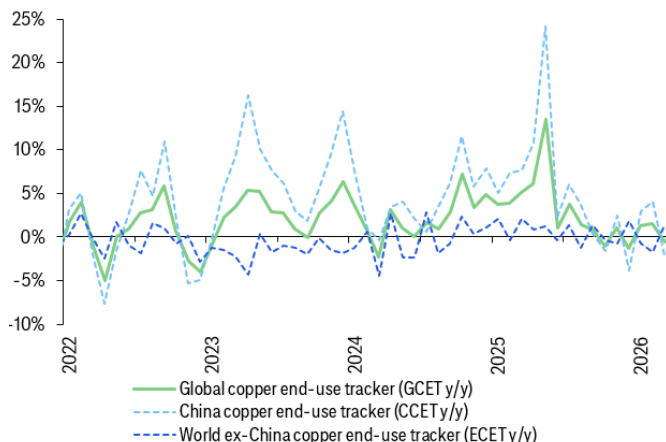
Figure 14. Stronger PMIs imply likely recent resilience in cyclical copper demand, but impact of SoH yet to be felt



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Source: Citi Research

Figure 15. Weaker China copper end-use (note China's power-related and copper semi exports are captured as Ex-China end-use) has slowed global copper consumption

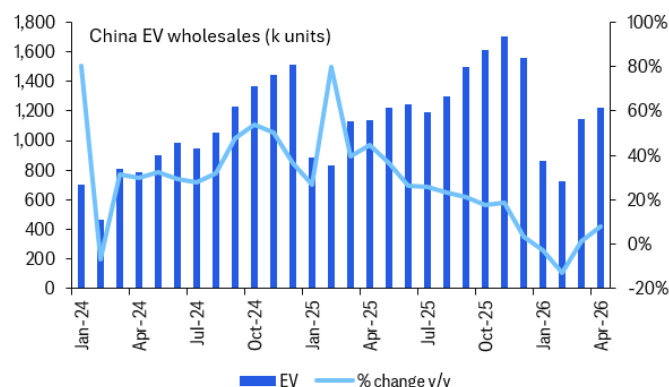


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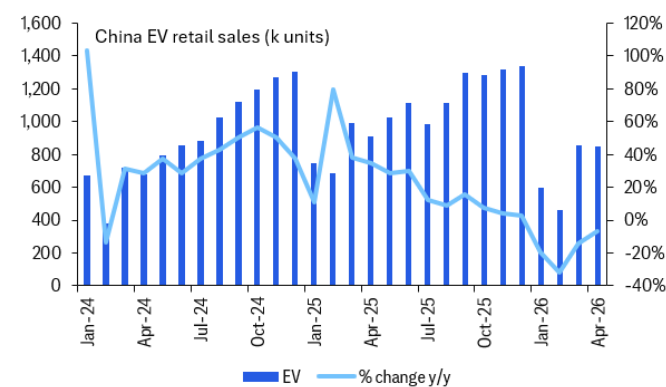
China's implied copper end-use had a subdued start to 1Q'26. Based on our tracker, implied copper consumption declined by ~2% YoY in March. The weakness largely reflects a softer domestic EV and ICE auto sales environment and an expected major y/y decline in reported renewable installations due to the base effect of a front-loaded reporting spike in 2025. (Report power installations at 8.7GW solar in March (down ~60% YoY) and wind at 4.7GW (down 11% YoY). We expect China's solar installation pipeline to remain comparatively soft through 1H'26, with recent April prints broadly in line with expectations. Automotive-related copper consumption remains muted, reflecting weak domestic auto sales. Elsewhere, seasonal and weather-related factors are providing some support to copper demand from the consumer appliances segment. However, property/real estate-linked demand continues to decline and remains a headwind (albeit softening headwind given the falling share of overall consumption).

Figure 16. China EV wholesales down 1% y/y in 4M'26



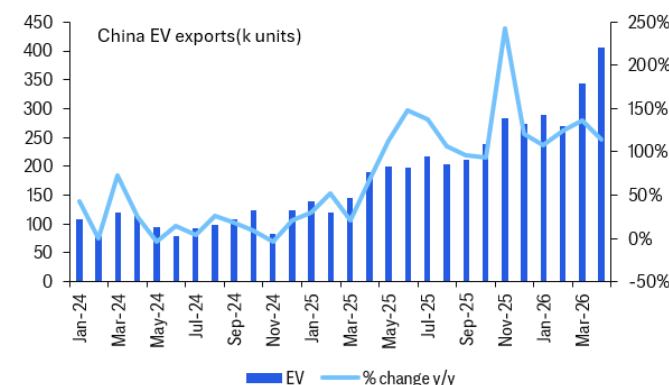
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Source: Citi Research, CPCA

Figure 17. China EV retail sales down 17% y/y in 4M'26



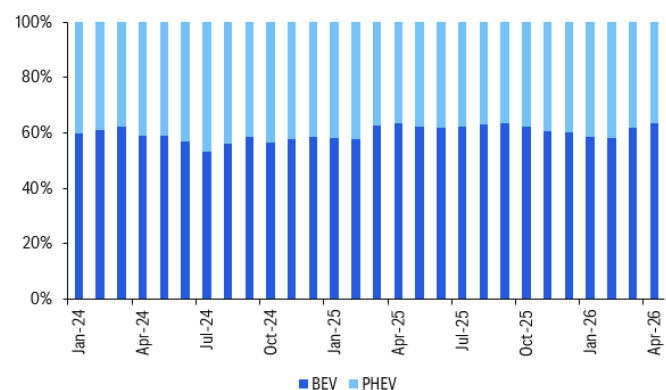
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Source: Citi Research, CPCA

Figure 18. China EV exports surged 120% y/y in 4M'26



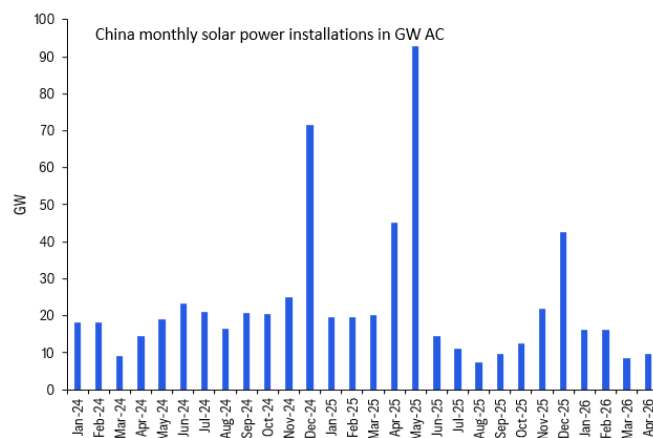
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Source: Citi Research, CPCA

Figure 19. BEVs have gained market share over the last 12 months



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Source: Citi Research, CPCA

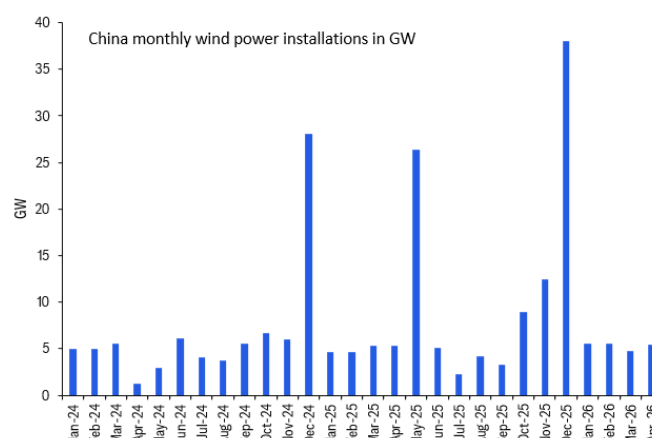
Figure 20. China's solar installations understandably softer after reporting spike ahead of policy changes last year



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Source: Citi Research, NEA

Figure 21. China's wind installations growing albeit at a slower pace

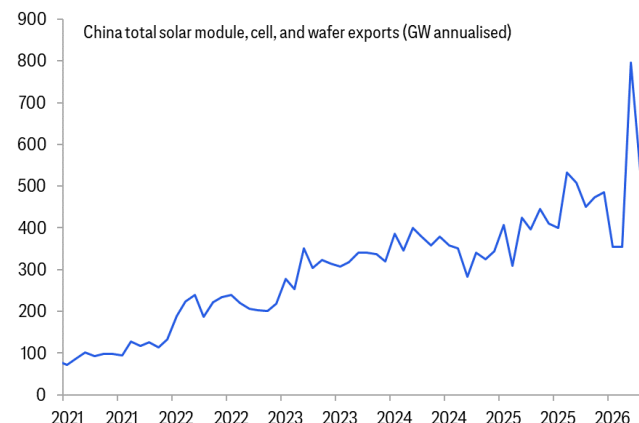


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Source: Citi Research, NEA

We think China refined copper consumption (distinct from end-use) has been supported by robust export activity, particularly in solar, batteries and EVs. Our tracker includes total China auto production (including exports) within China end-use. Exports of China semi-finished products and power equipment for generation, grid, and storage is captured as ex-China end use even as it drives China raw copper consumption. China exported 1.3mn EVs in the first four months of 2026, representing ~120% YoY growth, while overall auto exports increased by ~70% YoY over the same period. Ongoing geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, and the resulting increase in fuel prices (particularly across emerging markets) has accelerated the shift towards EVs, supporting demand for China-manufactured vehicles. While domestic solar installations have been weak year-to-date, export demand for solar products remains strong. Shipments of solar modules, wafers and cells have been robust, with solar module exports consistently annualizing at ~230–250GW, driven by diversified demand across regions including Africa and Europe.

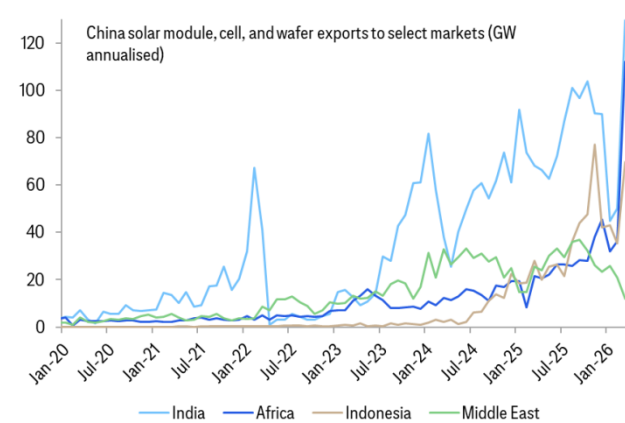
Figure 22. China's solar exports continue to trend higher in early 2026



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Source: Citi Research, Ember

Figure 23. ...growth in solar shipments to developing economies remains strong, Africa sees a notable spike



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Source: Citi Research, Ember

Implied copper consumption ex- China rose ~1% YoY in March 2026. Tracked cyclical consumption remained sluggish but is offset by assumed strong projected annual power-related end-use growth (reflected in stronger China power equipment exports to ex-China). Rising AI-related capex is helping drive demand for power infrastructure equipment, including switchgears and transformers, thereby supporting copper consumption. In addition, continued growth in solar, wind and BESS installations outside of China is contributing to incremental demand. Manufacturing sentiment has been on an uptrend, with particularly strong PMI prints from the US which we may see reflected in some underlying tracked cyclical consumption series in the coming months.

Figure 24. Summary Table: Global, China, and World ex-China Copper Monthly End-Use Tracker (total demand including grid and power generation), implied % y/y change

	Jan-25	Feb-25	Mar-25	Apr-25	May-25	Jun-25	Jul-25	Aug-25	Sep-25	Oct-25	Nov-25	Dec-25	Jan-26	Feb-26	Mar-26
Global Cu end-use tracker (GCET)	3.8%	3.8%	5.1%	6.1%	13.5%	1.0%	3.8%	1.4%	0.8%	-1.1%	1.0%	-1.4%	1.3%	1.6%	-0.6%
Building and Construction	5%	-1%	0%	-3%	-4%	-3%	1%	-4%	-4%	-7%	-5%	-4%	0%	11%	-6%
Consumer appliances	6%	6%	4%	-1%	0%	4%	4%	3%	-1%	-4%	-3%	-2%	0%	0%	4%
Machinery and Equipment	0%	-1%	1%	0%	0%	1%	1%	2%	2%	0%	1%	1%	1%	0%	0%
Automotive	7%	17%	14%	15%	10%	7%	12%	10%	14%	7%	3%	0%	-3%	-9%	-2%
EV	26%	55%	38%	40%	30%	21%	26%	24%	25%	18%	12%	5%	-3%	-11%	1%
ICE	-2%	2%	2%	2%	-1%	-1%	3%	1%	5%	-1%	-5%	-4%	-3%	-8%	-4%
Power Grid (From Annual Est.)	3%	3%	3%	3%	2%	2%	2%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%
Power Generation (Partly From Annual Est.)	1%	1%	32%	71%	169%	-16%	-4%	-8%	-19%	-9%	17%	-11%	11%	12%	-16%
Total Cyclical	4%	3%	2%	1%	2%	2%	4%	1%	1%	-2%	-1%	0%	1%	2%	1%
Total Energy Transition	10%	15%	28%	58%	119%	-4%	-3%	1%	-2%	4%	10%	-9%	1%	-1%	-6%
World ex-China Cu end-use tracker (ECET)	2%	0%	2%	1%	1%	0%	1%	-1%	1%	0%	-1%	2%	-1%	-2%	1%
Building and Construction	3%	1%	3%	0%	1%	1%	2%	-2%	2%	-1%	-1%	2%	-2%	-4%	1%
Consumer appliances	-1%	-7%	-3%	-1%	0%	-4%	-2%	-5%	-4%	-4%	-3%	-2%	-4%	-3%	-1%
Machinery and Equipment	-1%	0%	0%	0%	0%	-1%	2%	-1%	0%	-1%	1%	1%	2%	0%	0%
Automotive	6%	3%	10%	8%	2%	-3%	3%	1%	7%	1%	-6%	2%	-5%	-5%	-4%
EV	24%	23%	34%	16%	7%	0%	9%	14%	21%	5%	-21%	-2%	-11%	-7%	0%
ICE	2%	-2%	5%	6%	1%	-4%	2%	-2%	3%	-1%	-2%	3%	-3%	-4%	-5%
Power Grid (From Annual Est.)	6%	6%	5%	5%	5%	4%	5%	6%	7%	7%	8%	9%	10%	11%	11%
Power Generation (From Annual Est.)	6%	5%	5%	4%	4%	4%	5%	6%	7%	8%	9%	10%	11%	13%	14%
China Cu end-use tracker (CCET)	5%	7%	8%	11%	24%	2%	6%	4%	0%	-2%	2%	-4%	3%	4%	-2%
Building and Construction	9%	-1%	0%	-6%	-7%	-5%	1%	-6%	-8%	-12%	-9%	-7%	0%	20%	-12%
Consumer appliances	8%	8%	5%	-2%	1%	6%	6%	4%	-1%	-6%	-4%	-3%	0%	0%	5%
Machinery and Equipment	-3%	-3%	1%	-1%	-2%	2%	2%	10%	6%	0%	5%	1%	4%	4%	0%
Automotive	7%	43%	18%	23%	19%	20%	22%	20%	20%	13%	10%	-2%	-2%	-14%	0%
EV	27%	77%	40%	49%	39%	31%	33%	28%	27%	22%	23%	7%	1%	-13%	1%
ICE	-9%	14%	-4%	-5%	-6%	5%	6%	8%	9%	-1%	-10%	-17%	-5%	-16%	-3%
Power Grid (From Annual Est.)	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%	2%
Power Generation	-3%	-3%	76%	170%	350%	-31%	-13%	-25%	-42%	-23%	23%	-16%	11%	12%	-46%

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Appendix A-1

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